2.3 Independence and Annexation

A "political football" is an issue that political opponents fight over. In 1836, the issue of annexing Texas became a political football in the United States, and it would be kicked back and forth for nearly a decade.

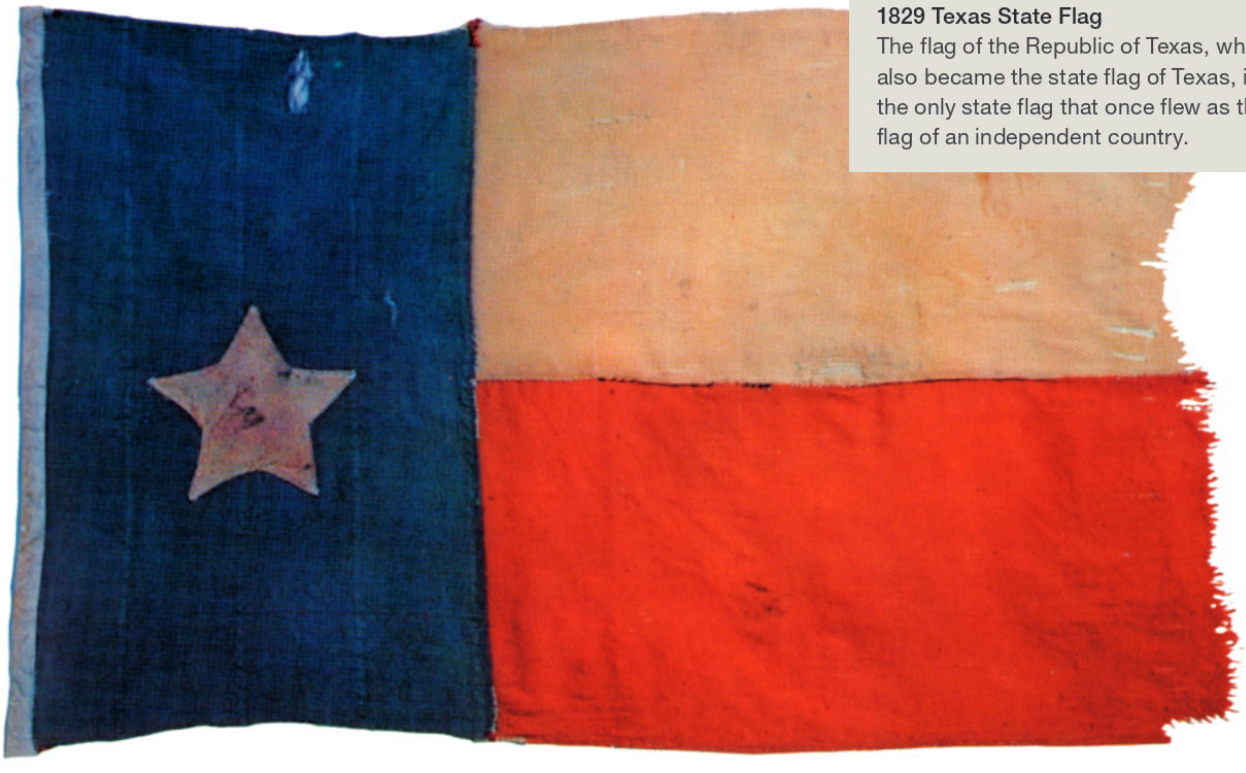
MAIN IDEA The annexation of the Republic of Texas as the 28th state caused tension between northern and southern states.

THE LONE STAR REPUBLIC

After the Texas War for Independence, Texas became an independent nation, the Republic of Texas. Texans elected Sam Houston as their first president. The flag of Texas, with a single star, earned the nation the nickname of **Lone Star Republic**. As proud as they were of their victory, Texans knew they were vulnerable to further attacks from Mexico. They also lacked an established economy. Most Texans favored annexation by the United States.

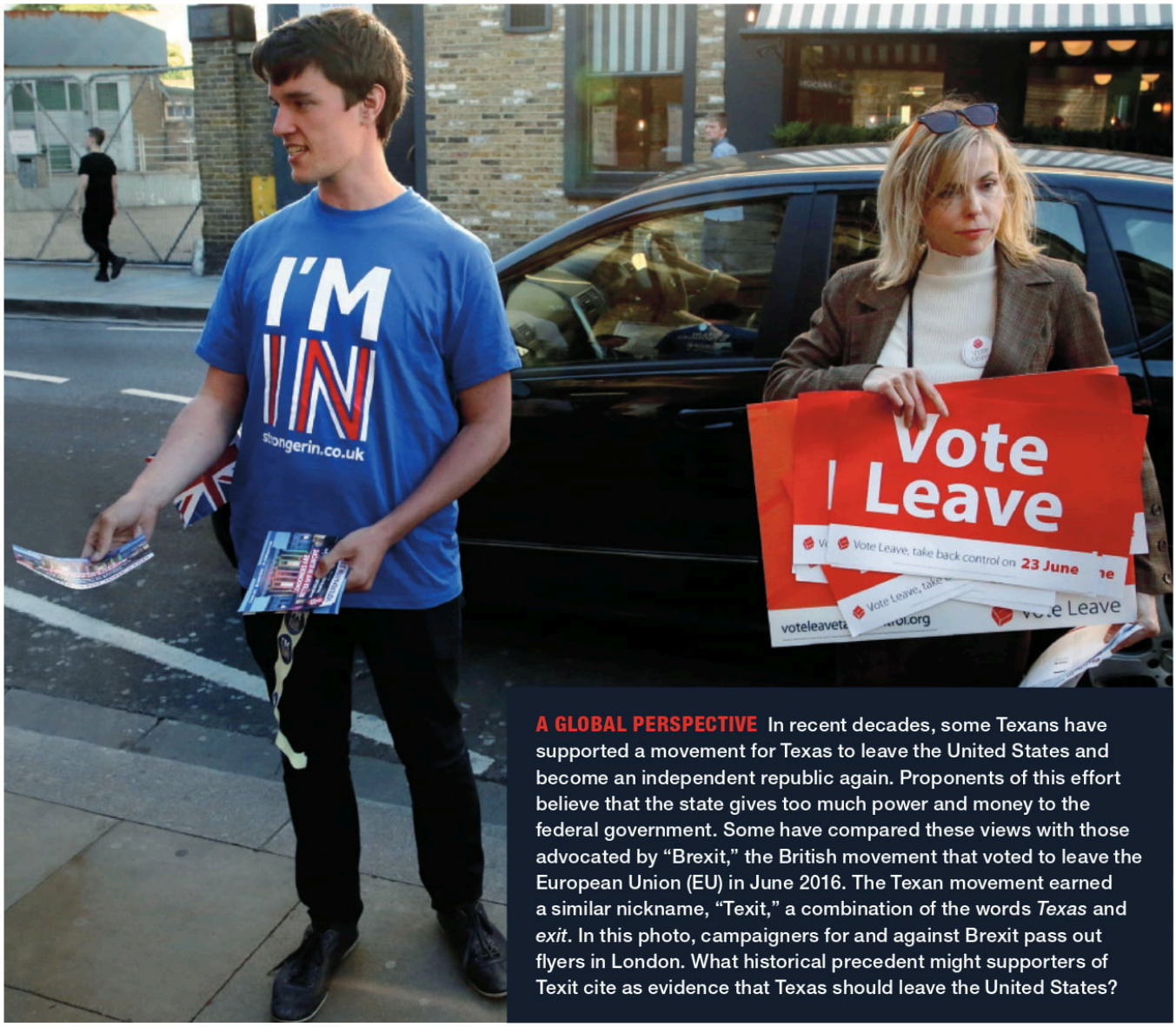
The United States initially rejected this plan, however. In 1836 and 1837, President Andrew Jackson and his successor Martin Van Buren turned down Texas lawmakers' proposals. For one thing, they argued, annexing Texas would hurt American relations with Mexico and perhaps even lead to war. They also knew the American people were divided on the question, primarily because of the issue of slavery.

Before independence, Texas clashed with Mexico over slavery, which was prohibited by Mexican law. The ongoing use of enslaved labor in the Republic of Texas also became a concern for northern states in the United States. Admitting Texas as a state would upset the balance between states that had outlawed slavery and states where slavery was still practiced. Presidents Jackson and Van Buren argued that annexation was not in the best interest of the country.



1829 Texas State Flag
The flag of the Republic of Texas, which also became the state flag of Texas, is the only state flag that once flew as the flag of an independent country.

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A GLOBAL PERSPECTIVE In recent decades, some Texans have supported a movement for Texas to leave the United States and become an independent republic again. Proponents of this effort believe that the state gives too much power and money to the federal government. Some have compared these views with those advocated by "Brexit," the British movement that voted to leave the European Union (EU) in June 2016. The Texan movement earned a similar nickname, "Texit," a combination of the words *Texas* and *exit*. In this photo, campaigners for and against Brexit pass out flyers in London. What historical precedent might supporters of Texit cite as evidence that Texas should leave the United States?

ANNEXATION OF TEXAS

Texas remained independent for almost 10 years. Then, in 1844, annexation gained a supporter in the White House—**James K. Polk**. Polk had been the Speaker of the House and the governor of Tennessee, but he was not a superstar politician. When the Democrats nominated him for president in 1844, he was an unknown candidate who had little chance of winning. But despite running as an unknown against Henry Clay, the prominent Whig candidate, Polk won the presidency, barely, with 49.5 percent of the popular vote and an electoral college **margin**, or amount by which something is won or lost, of 170–105.

As president, Polk managed to turn his political ambitions into policy. He supported the ideas of manifest destiny and favored the annexation of Texas. He also believed that the United States should take complete control of the Oregon Territory, up to the latitude of 54° 40'. One of Polk's campaign slogans was "Fifty-four forty or fight!" Polk brought an enthusiasm to his presidency for expanding the country. Under his leadership, Texas became the 28th state.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What were the arguments against the annexation of Texas as a state?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** How was Polk's argument for annexation informed by the concept of manifest destiny?
3. **EVALUATE** What made James K. Polk an attractive but unlikely candidate for president?

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